

Guidelines for designing proseminars in the B.A. programme Politics – Public Administration – Management at the University of Konstanz

Last update: 03.02.2025

1. Proseminar concept

In the proseminars, students develop **basic skills in the area of academic work**. The teaching of these skills is embedded in a subject-specific topic. The seminar topic can be freely chosen by the lecturers. The proseminars are assigned to the areas of Politics and Public administration/Management. Students in the B.A. programme Politics – Public Administration – Management must attend two proseminars, usually in the second semester (summer semester, proseminar I) and in the third semester (winter semester, proseminar II). Competences in the area of academic work develop continuously and consecutively in proseminars I and proseminars II. **Proseminars I** introduce students to the basic techniques of academic work and the handling of academic literature. **Proseminars II**, on the other hand, focus more strongly on writing skills, including the written elaboration of research questions, theories and hypotheses.

The advantages of this concept are a high practical orientation and application focus as well as the possibility of close supervision by the lecturers. To ensure that students in the different proseminars have similar learning conditions, all proseminars I and II should have a comparable structure and pursue the same qualification goals in the area of academic work. The performance assessments in the proseminars of one type should also be comparable. The obligatory components of proseminars I and II are listed below. The lecturers can make use of various support offers from the Communication, Information, Media Centre (KIM) and the Writing Centre. **Apart from the mandatory components, the programme of the proseminars can be designed flexibly.**

2. Standardised areas of proseminars

1. **Uniform learning goals in the area of academic work** (see below).
2. **Integration of the asynchronous e-learning elements.** Certain topics (see below) are taught asynchronously - via self-study units in ILIAS - and supplemented by a test/quiz or a written assignment. The self-study units and the work assignments for the students are available in the ILIAS course "Teaching academic work" and should be copied into your own ILIAS course and adapted if necessary. The lecturers guide the self-study units (through preparation and follow-up) and ensure that the content is embedded in the respective topic.
3. **Integration of the compulsory teaching sessions with the staff of the KIM or the Writing Centre.** The following expertise must be used for one of the proseminar sessions (see also below). Proseminar I: a teaching session with the subject specialist from the KIM on strategies and techniques for literature and information research. Proseminar II: a teaching session with a member of staff from the Writing Centre on writing techniques. The lessons are organised in consultation with the teachers according to their needs. To ensure that the techniques of academic work are thematically embedded, teachers should attend the relevant session.
4. **Uniform performance assessments** in the proseminars I and II (see below).

5. **Standardisation of the recommended citation style:** “APA” is defined as the recommended citation style of the department.

3. Structure of the proseminars

The proseminars consist of the following uniform components:

- 1) The **course sessions** with the teacher, in which the subject content is linked to the learning goals in the area of scientific work;
- 2) **Two to three self-study e-learning elements** in ILIAS, to be worked on asynchronously by the students; the self-study elements have to be prepared and followed up together with the lecturers within the framework of the proseminars (the self-study elements are available in the ILIAS course “Teaching academic work” for copying and pasting into the ILIAS course of the respective proseminar);
- 3) A course session with the **subject specialist from the KIM in proseminar I** (appointment via judith.heeg@uni-konstanz.de) or **member of staff from the Writing Centre in proseminar II** (appointment via stephanie.kahsay@uni-konstanz.de).

With the exception of the above-mentioned compulsory elements, the programme of the proseminar can be designed in a flexible way.

3.1. Proseminar I „Basics of academic writing” (summer semester)

1) Academic work techniques to be covered in proseminar I:

- Development of the topic and the research question for the literature research;
- Literature research (teaching session with the KIM);
- Literature management (self-study unit);
- Literature analysis, preparation of excerpts or response papers (if necessary with the materials on genre awareness from the Writing Centre);
- Critical reading and reproduction of academic texts (self-study unit);
- Structure and procedure for writing academic papers;
- Correct citation and plagiarism prevention (self-study unit);
- Guidance on the use of AI tools in the context of scientific work;
- Designing presentations.

2) Self-study units in ILIAS (to be embedded and supervised by the teacher):

- Critical reading and reproduction of academic texts;
- Citing, avoiding plagiarising and using reference management software (Endnote/Zotero).

3) Teaching session with the KIM:

Strategies and techniques for information/literature research (needs-based design; timing to be agreed).

4) Required performance assessments:

- Presentation* (max. 10 to 15 minutes);

- Response paper* (approx. 500 words);
- Seminar paper - elaboration of the state of research (approx. 3000 words).

* One of the two performances may be ungraded (formative).

3.2. Proseminar II „Advanced academic writing“ (winter semester)

1) Academic work techniques to be covered in proseminar II:

- Research question and topic identification; development of a research question for the seminar paper (available as a self-study unit);
- Hypothesis and theory development;
- Structure and procedure for writing academic papers (outline etc.);
- Reflection on own writing process (available as a self-study unit);
- Classification of the research question in the scientific debate, identification of a research gap;
- Exposé for a scientific paper (short exposé/outline and detailed exposé);
- Text revision and peer feedback on the research projects of other fellow students (available as a self-study unit);
- Guidance on the use of AI tools in the context of scientific work.

2) At least two of the following three self-study units in ILIAS (to be embedded and supervised by the teacher):

- Reflection on own writing process;
- Development of a research question for the seminar paper using the three-step approach;
- Text revision and peer feedback.

3) Teaching session with the Writing Centre:

On demand, e.g. a practical session on flash exposé, outline of the seminar paper, either as one session of 90 minutes or in two short units of 45 minutes each (needs-based design; timing to be agreed).

4) Required performance assessments:

- Presentation* (max. 10 to 15 minutes)
- Short exposé / Sketch / Short Outline* (approx. two pages and bibliography)
- Seminar paper in the form of a detailed exposé - elaboration of the research question, theory and hypothesis(es) (10 - 12 pages)

* One of the two performances may be ungraded (formative).

Note: It has proved useful to organise one or two sessions in the form of a colloquium in which students present their short exposés. These are then discussed by the other seminar participants. Suggestions for improvement can be made by both the students and the teacher.